

APPSUMO

Moonshot:

A Post-AppSumo Launch Guide for Partners



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Moonshot: A Post-AppSumo Launch Guide for Partners

You did the hard part. You took your business from zero to a successful launch on AppSumo. Now you're on the other side.

That means you face a choice: You can fall for shiny object syndrome and try to tackle a thousand little ideas...

Or you can double down on your success by implementing the few things that actually help you maximize your newfound customers, publicity, and cash.

At AppSumo, we've seen a lot of businesses take their next steps after launching on our platform. Some of them excel. Others flounder. We created this guide to help you maximize this post-launch period and take your business to new heights.

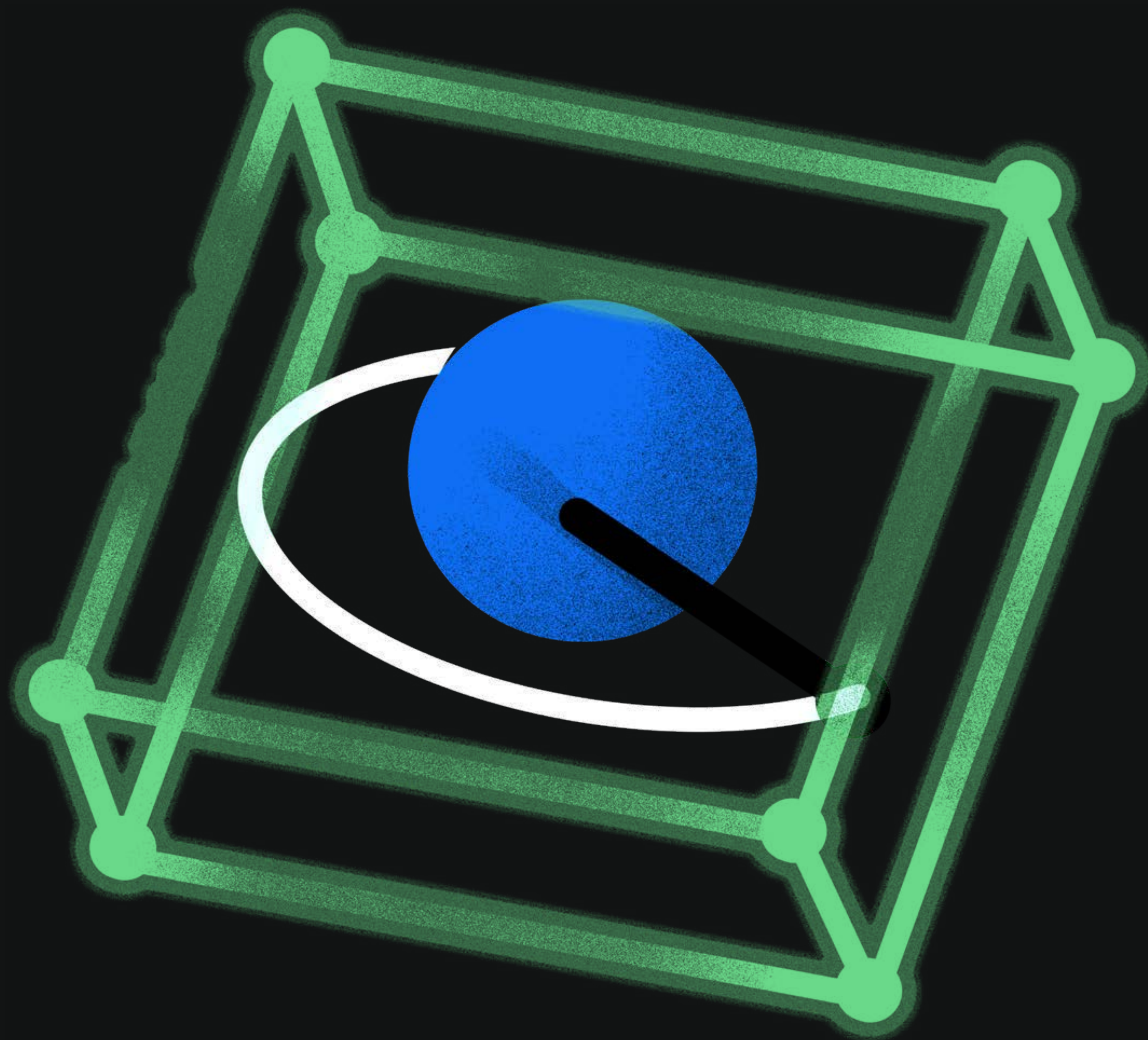
We've narrowed our recommendations down to just 5 categories:

- ① Build an affiliate program
- ② Build a community
- ③ Gather (and distribute) reviews
- ④ Generate MRR and upsells
- ⑤ Repeat AppSumo campaigns

So put on your goggles. We're diving in.

01

Build an affiliate program



Campaign	Affiliates	Net Revenue
• ARTSMART Affiliates artsmart.ai View monthly summary • 20% commission on all payments • 60-day cookie New affiliates can join this campaign at https://artsmart.getrewardful.com/signup  321 affiliates \$6,777.48 USD		

In any business, your best marketers are often your customers.

And Sumo-lings aren't just your average customers. In fact, many of them are entrepreneurs who love nothing more than to cheer on other founders and their products. They'll find any excuse to promote what they love.

A lot of Sumo-lings also have audiences, followers, and subscribers of their own. So, how do you motivate more of these customers to become marketers?

The best first thing you can do is give Sumo-lings a big reason to talk about your product—by building an affiliate program.

Here's what you should know.

Affiliate commission structure

You can set up an affiliate commission structure in numerous ways.

Here are three common variations:

- 1 **Consistent:** This is the simplest structure. In this case, you have an affiliate commission structure that's the same no matter who purchased the product. For example, a common setup is to offer affiliates 20% of the sticker price for every sale they drive.
- 2 **Large, then small:** Another popular commission structure is to reward new buyer purchases more than you reward purchases made by returning customers. For example, you may offer 50% commission to affiliates who bring a new customer to your product. You might only pay 10% to the same affiliate who encourages a past customer to return.
- 3 **Up the ante with recurring payments:** If you offer a product with a monthly subscription, then you can up the ante for affiliates by offering an ongoing cut of every subscription. This is a payment structure used by Medium.com, for example. When someone signs up to join Medium as a monthly subscriber, the writer gets an indefinite affiliate kickback into the future. This is a good way to stand out from other affiliate programs.

Payout schedule

A regular and predictable payout schedule, such as bi-weekly payouts, can help sustain the interest and commitment of affiliates. But the real determining factor of your affiliate payout structure should be your return policy.

If your return policy is longer than your affiliate payout, then you're asking for trouble. You might end up paying affiliate kickbacks on purchases that will soon be refunded. That's a quick way to waste a lot of cash.

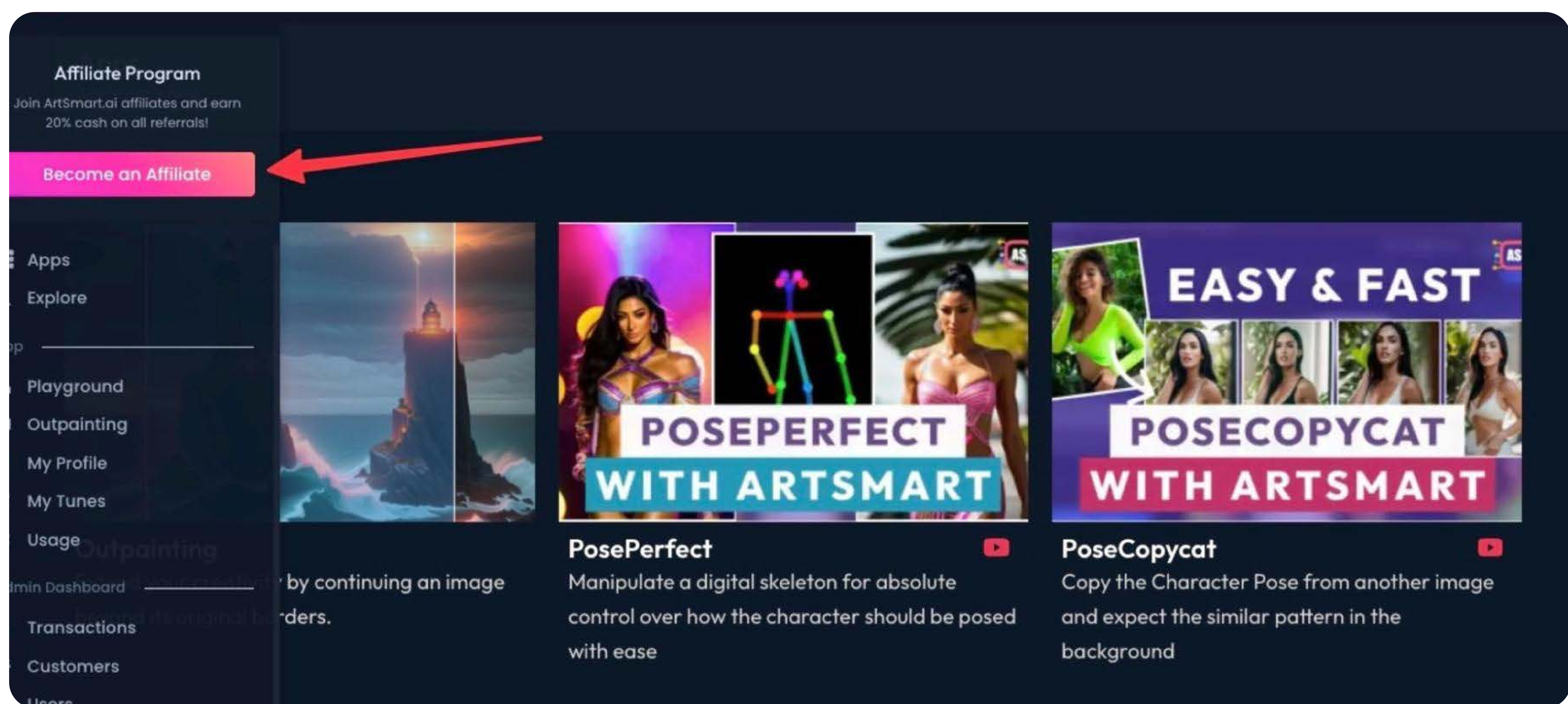
Instead, **make sure your affiliate payout period is at least the same length of time as your refund policy.**

We do this here at AppSumo. Our affiliates are paid on net 60-day pay terms because we have a 60-day return policy on all products.

Grow your affiliate network

So... how do you attract high-quality affiliates? Here are several best practices:

- **Reach out directly to top reviewers:** 5-star product reviews are a window into your most satisfied customers. They're already stating publicly that they enjoy your product. It's not much of a stretch beyond that for them to tell friends and family. Reach out to these customers directly.
- **Use all your normal marketing channels:** In a way, an affiliate program is like a new product in your tool suite. Your best bet is to treat it like one. Use your marketing engines: Send out dedicated newsletters, post on social media, create a dedicated landing page that ranks on Google for "affiliate program [product name]," and so on.
- **Integrate your affiliate signup link into the tool:** Where do your potential affiliates and fans most likely spend their time? In your product! That's why you should create a dedicated button for people to learn about your affiliate program.

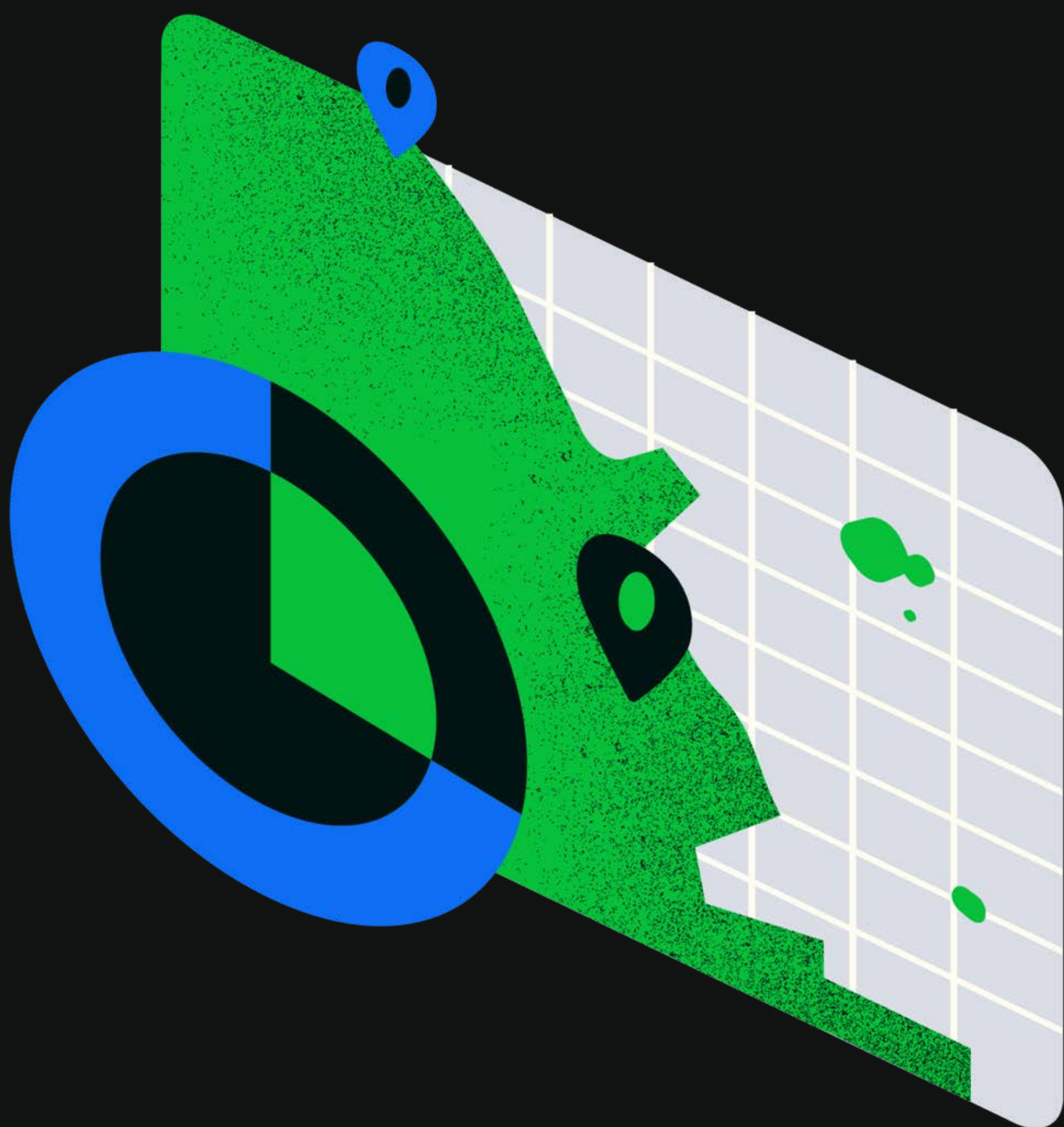


Recruiting more affiliates is integral to expanding your network. This can be done through strategies such as email blasts or creating an affiliate signup email in the account creation email sequence.

Affiliate network growth hack

AppSumo has its own affiliate program. When your AppSumo deal ends, you can look for Sumo-lings who are already promoting your deal and reach out to them personally. If they've been using an AppSumo affiliate code, all you have to do is ask them to swap that code for your own. You get more customers. They have a new reason to promote your product. All it takes is a simple message.

02 Build a community



It's one thing to have customers. It's an even better thing to have fans. The highest reward is connecting your fans with one another and forming a community—where your product is the glue that holds everyone together. Here's why:

- Customers can eventually double as customer support, helping one another overcome learning curves
- Customers help other customers get more out of your product by discussing niche use cases or features
- Customers who feel like they're part of a larger community are more likely to recommend your product, buy again in the future, or stick with it for the long term

Everyone knows that building community means playing the long game. But here's where you have an advantage: Your influx of Sumo-ling customers is a natural launching pad for fostering a community around your product.

Community starts in the launch

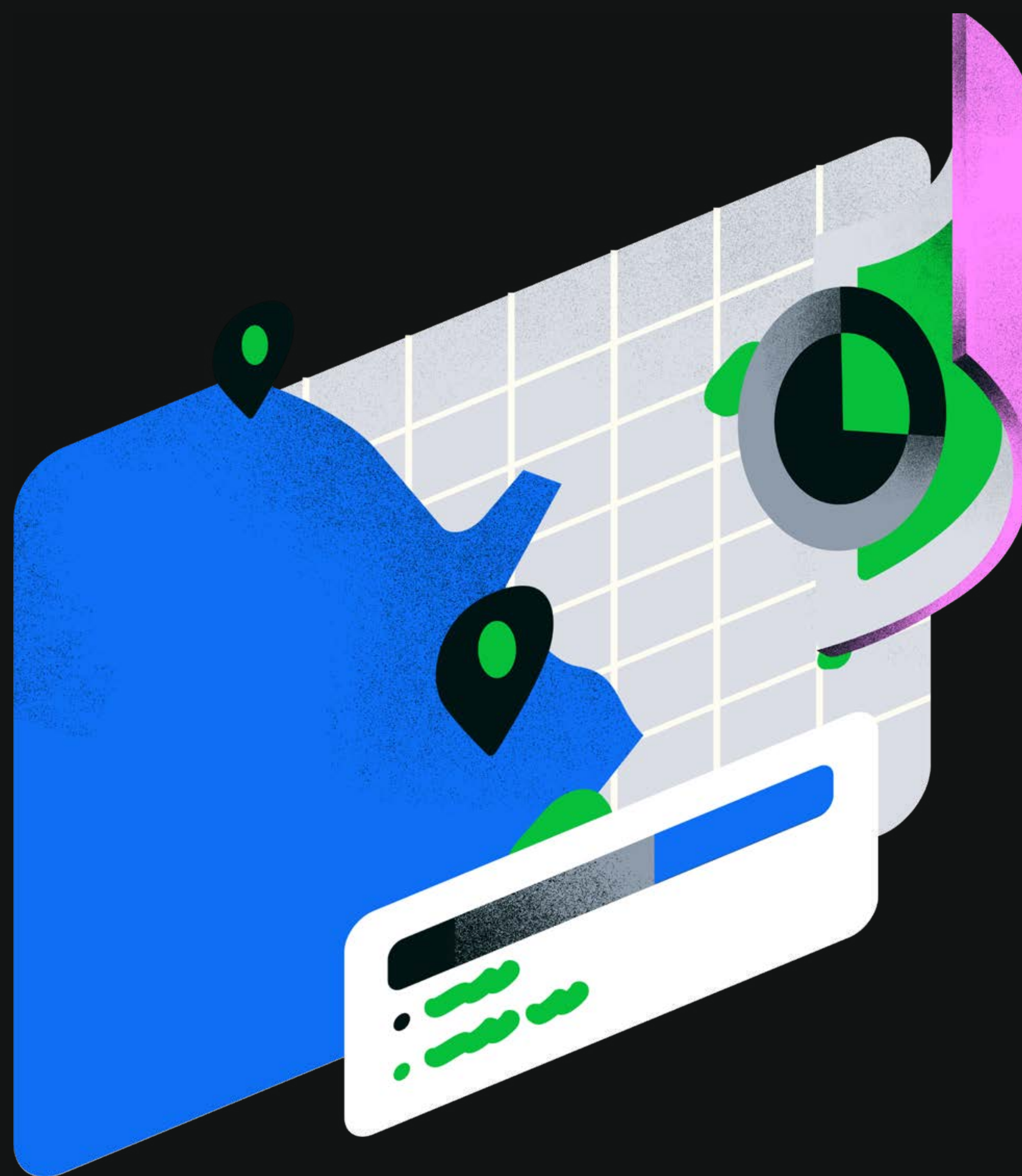
Don't underestimate the size and impact of tool-related communities. Multiple tools that went through AppSumo have since built communities with tens of thousands of members. Dukaan alone has more than [70,000 members](#) in its community.

The great advantage of Sumo-lings? They're already community-oriented. AppSumo fosters a massive community of founders, business owners, and freelancers. For Sumo-lings, community is a necessary part of what it means to be in business.

So there's no better time to start your community than right after your AppSumo launch.

Start your community by going back through some of the core aspects of your new customer documentation and onboarding:

- Be active in all customer touchpoints including deal pages, ticket support, webmail support, roadmap page, and social media.
- Capitalize on email onboarding sequences to introduce new customers to your brand and invite them to join your community
- Create polls to understand customer needs and preferences



Community building 101

Where you have your community—Facebook Groups, Slack, Discord, Circle—matters less than the fact that you're putting in the effort to foster said community. In other words, it's not about the platform—it's about how you use it.

Community building tends to work best when you have the following practices in play:

- **Set clear guidelines:** Put your goals, rules, and expectations into writing. Make sure these written guidelines are easy for any community member to access. These rules will form necessary boundaries so that your community can thrive.
- **Engage, engage, engage:** The best way to grow a community and ensure people stick around for the long term is to keep members engaged. That means sharing stories, asking questions, and posting questionnaires and feedback requests. It also means responding to comments and (especially!) tool-specific questions.
- **Incentivize connection:** Community isn't a one-person show. It's something that brings many people together. Find ways to encourage members to engage with one another. This might include creating dedicated channels in Slack or Discord for people to connect on specific topics. Or it might be as simple as tagging certain members in other people's posts to request their opinions.
- **Provide value (that they can't get elsewhere):** What's sticky about your community? Do you have regular private Q&A sessions or webinars? Do you offer regular giveaways to community members? Whatever your ideas are, you need a big reason for community members to sign up and stick around.
- **Gather feedback and optimize:** One of the best things about having a community is the ability to receive feedback about your product—or the community itself. As the feedback rolls in, take it into account as you discuss new changes and features for your roadmap.

[Learn how building a community helped Plutio reach 10,000 users.](#)

Build the ultimate feedback loop

Here's one of the biggest secrets for making your community a sticky place: Give your community real power to influence the future of your product.

You can crowdsource feedback and future feature ideas. Make this community the central hub for informing your product roadmap.

Who better to tell you what features or opportunities you're missing than the people who use your product every day?

Community-led product development carries two reinforcing benefits:

- 1 Community members tell you the exact features, bug fixes, and updates they're looking for in your product.
- 2 The more you build the product to meet the collective needs of your community, the more your community will stick with your product and remain active members of your community. Feeling heard goes a long way.

03 Gather (and distribute) reviews



You've already earned reviews on AppSumo. Now it's time to share those reviews across the web to make it look like the entire internet is talking about your product.

Positive reviews convey the message to future prospective customers that your product delivers on the promise you're making. It's social proof, a sign of demand and customer satisfaction.

It's not enough to simply have reviews on a single website. Many people, when deciding whether or not to purchase a product, will scour their favorite review websites to learn about your product.

In the world of business software, those websites often include **G2 and Capterra**. So your next step should be getting reviews on those websites.

Get the whole world talking

How can you make sure people are talking about your product? Reach out to happy customers to request reviews. There are two primary ways to request reviews:

- ➊ Directly through personalized outreach
- ➋ Automating parts of your onboarding process so that positive reviews are requested during key moments

Both of these methods have unique strengths.

The power of personalization

Every direct interaction with a customer is an opportunity to request a review.

Give yourself this rule: Every time you have a positive interaction with a customer (for example, during onboarding, customer support, or on social media), ask them if they're willing to share their experience in a review.

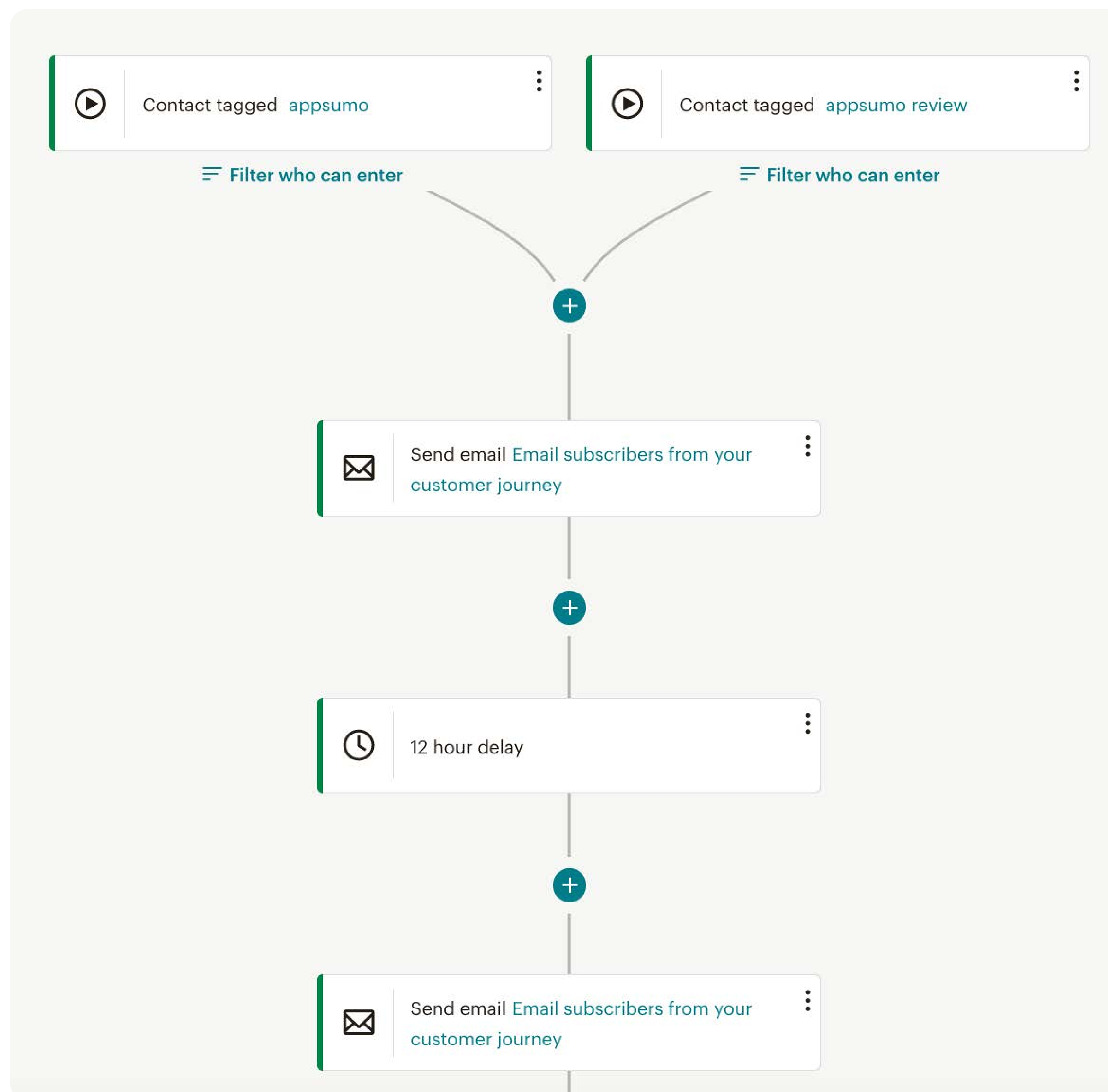
You don't want to just ask for any review here. Personal interactions give you the power to request tailored reviews. It all comes down to the language you use. Here are two examples:

- ❶ **The standard way:** "Thank you for your feedback about [Product]. Do you mind leaving a review about your experience? It would really help my business."
- ❷ **The powerful way:** "Your story about how you use [Product] was very helpful to hear. Would you mind sharing your story in a review for my product? It could really help other people understand what is possible with [Product]."

In the first review request, the generic language will likely lead to a lot of generic reviews. ("It's a good tool.")

The second review request is more specific and personal. You aren't merely asking for a review. You're asking for the person to share their story and specific experience. ("I used [Product] to grow my business by...")

Automate review gathering



Asking each person who uses your product to leave a review is a highly effective way to drive reviews. But you also want to make sure people leave reviews on their own. It's more scalable that way.

Here are a few ideas on how to automate certain aspects of your review-gathering process:

- Create an automated email campaign that requests a review shortly (within 48 hours) of a new customer signing up for your tool. You want them to leave a review quickly while they're still exploring and highly curious about your product. (We've included an email sequence template below.)
- Implement a subtle popup or notification in your tool that requests reviews from your most consistent users. When someone has spent a lot of hours navigating your tool, there's a good chance they're getting a lot of value from it. You can nudge some of these power users to leave a review by requesting it within your app.

Consider incentives

Sometimes it pays to pay.

During your AppSumo campaign, we make it clear that you're not allowed to offer incentives to Sumo-lings in exchange for reviews. However, after your campaign ends, using incentives to encourage your next customers to leave reviews on other websites might be the right move for you.

Although other platforms' review systems are a free-for-all, at AppSumo, we try to keep the reviews as honest and transparent as possible. Allowing incentivized reviews could mislead potential customers.

Here's what the team at Adilo said about gathering reviews:

"What we did was very simple. Reach out to customers 1 day after purchase (their account is auto-tagged "AppSumo" 24 hours after signing up on Adilo, which funnels them into our sequence). The timeline is important as that is when the users have peak interest.

Then we made an offer to give us reviews on G2, Capterra, etc. in return for +1 tier upgrade free.

We directed them to a page where we explained step by step how to leave the reviews. This was done so we don't end up writing lengthy emails (most people can't stand it when an email becomes too long)."

Steal this email template to request reviews

It takes a lot of work to write a review-request email sequence from scratch. Use these examples from Adilo as a jumping-off point instead:

Email 1: Welcome to COMPANY [FNAME] -- Win Big with our AppSumo Deal!

Dear <<First Name>>,

Thank you for joining us on AppSumo and becoming a part of our journey. My name is [Name], and over the next few weeks, you'll be hearing a lot from me.

We want to offer you a special upgrade for our "XYZ feature" from X to Z (e.g., from 5 seats to 6 seats) entirely for free. We'll even go as far as providing you with "10 seats" at no additional cost.

All we ask in return is that you leave honest reviews for us on G2 and Capterra, as your feedback is invaluable to us. Your review can be as candid as you like, whether it's 1 star or 5 stars, based on your genuine experience with Adilo.

Here's how to claim your free +1 TIER upgrade now:

Keep your reviews detailed and honest.

Hurry and post the reviews now, as our reward offer is limited.

Email 2: [FNAME], How Many Stars for COMPANY? Get +1 Seat Upgrade Free

Dear <<First Name>>,

A few hours ago, I sent you an email with a fantastic opportunity. Leave a detailed review for us on G2, plus three other platforms, and we'll upgrade your account to the "NEXT TIER" completely free. This means, for every review platform you engage with, you'll receive an additional seat upgrade.

Claim your upgrade now:

[Insert link to post reviews & Get a free upgrade]

Please note that this offer is limited, and once we receive a sufficient number of reviews, we will conclude this deal. Act swiftly and post your reviews while our offer is still available.

Email 3: [FNAME], last chance to get upgraded to the "NEXT TIER" for FREE

Dear [FNAME],

A quick reminder: today is the last day we'll be accepting reviews on AppSumo and three other platforms for a FREE upgrade to the next tier. If you've already purchased Tier 5, we'll enhance your limits.

Here's how to post a review and claim your free upgrade:

[Insert link to post review & Get a free upgrade]

After today, we will no longer offer free upgrades for reviews, so don't miss this opportunity. Hurry and post your reviews now, and please notify us so we can expedite your upgrade.

Email 4: Last Reminder. Free Upgrade for AppSumo Buyers Ends Today

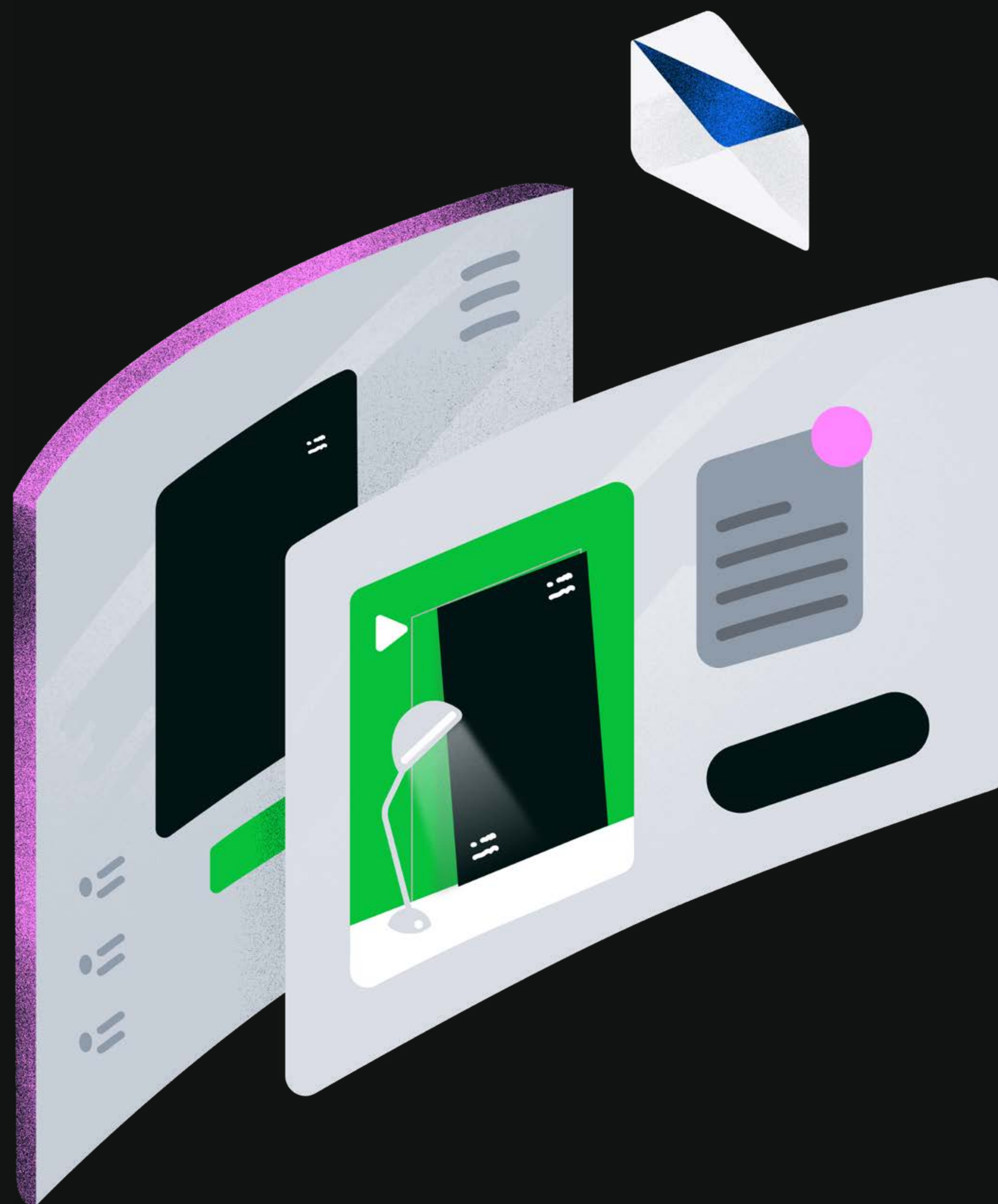
Final Reminder |FNAME|,

Today is the final day we'll be accepting reviews on AppSumo for a FREE upgrade to the "NEXT TIER." If you've already purchased Tier 5, we'll increase your limits.

Here's how to post a review and claim your free upgrade:

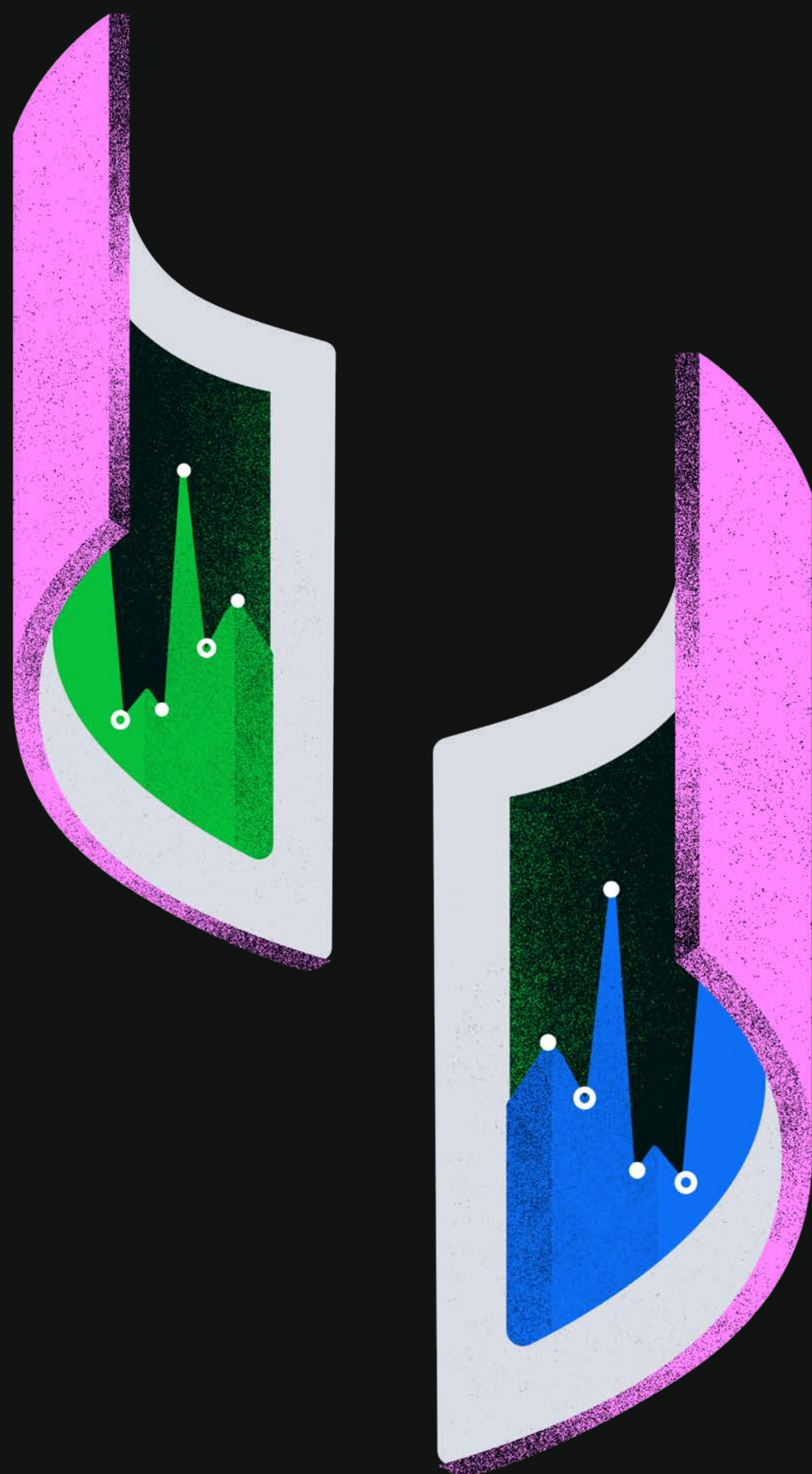
[Insert link to post review & Get a free upgrade]

After today, we will no longer offer free upgrades for reviews. Act quickly, post your reviews now, and notify us so we can process your upgrade promptly. Don't miss out on this opportunity.



04

Generate MRR & upsells



Most products that launch on AppSumo are lifetime deals, or what we call LTDs.

When your LTD on AppSumo ends, you're often flush with 500-3000+ excited new users as well as a nice bit of cash. The major question becomes: How do you translate that cash and customers into monthly recurring revenue?

Let's discuss.

Trying everything together

The reality is, the best way to upsell customers and improve monthly recurring revenue (MRR) is to first take the steps already provided throughout this guide.

If you...

- Build a small army of enthusiastic marketers using an affiliate program,
- Build a loyal community around your product and use feedback to continually improve the product,
- And gather reviews across the internet

... then the ongoing money often takes care of itself.

Let's unpack this in more detail.

The art of the upsell

An upsell is not a bait-and-switch. We do not endorse (or allow) hiding your best features from the AppSumo launch so that you can upsell those customers on them later.

No, there's an art to the upsell. You can do it in such a way that gets Sumo-lings ecstatic to pay you more money. It goes like this:

The best upsell is giving customers more of what they already love.

That means going back to the structure of your lifetime deal. Many lifetime deals have quantity limits built into them. The lifetime deal might cap the number of users, number of hours, size of a project, or how many clients you can service within the tool, and so on.

In this case, the upsell is as simple as raising the cap for your power users. Sell the ability to give access to more users. Sell additional hours. Sell larger project sizes. Sell the ability to add more clients to your portal or tool.

This is the ultimate upsell technique because the people most likely to want these upgrades are the same people already using and getting the most out of your tool.

You get more income. Passionate Sumo-lings get more of the product they love. It's a win-win.

LTD to MMR

After a successful campaign on AppSumo, the Pictory team was able to translate their learnings and opportunities after the launch into \$20k in MRR (using monthly subscription plans).

Looking at their example is the best way to learn how to turn your own lifetime deal into monthly recurring revenue. You can read the full story, but here is the high-level story in 3 parts:

1 Missed the deal? Have another

Pictory's team received many emails and messages after their launch had ended. Many people had missed the deal and were inquiring to see if they could still access the LTD.

Pictory created a go-to response to these requests: **"Sorry you missed the LTD, unfortunately, we can no longer plan on running this type of promotion, but here's a 50% discount code for our annual package."**

Pictory leaned into this messaging post-campaign to convert interested buyers into their monthly plans.

2 Referrals and affiliates

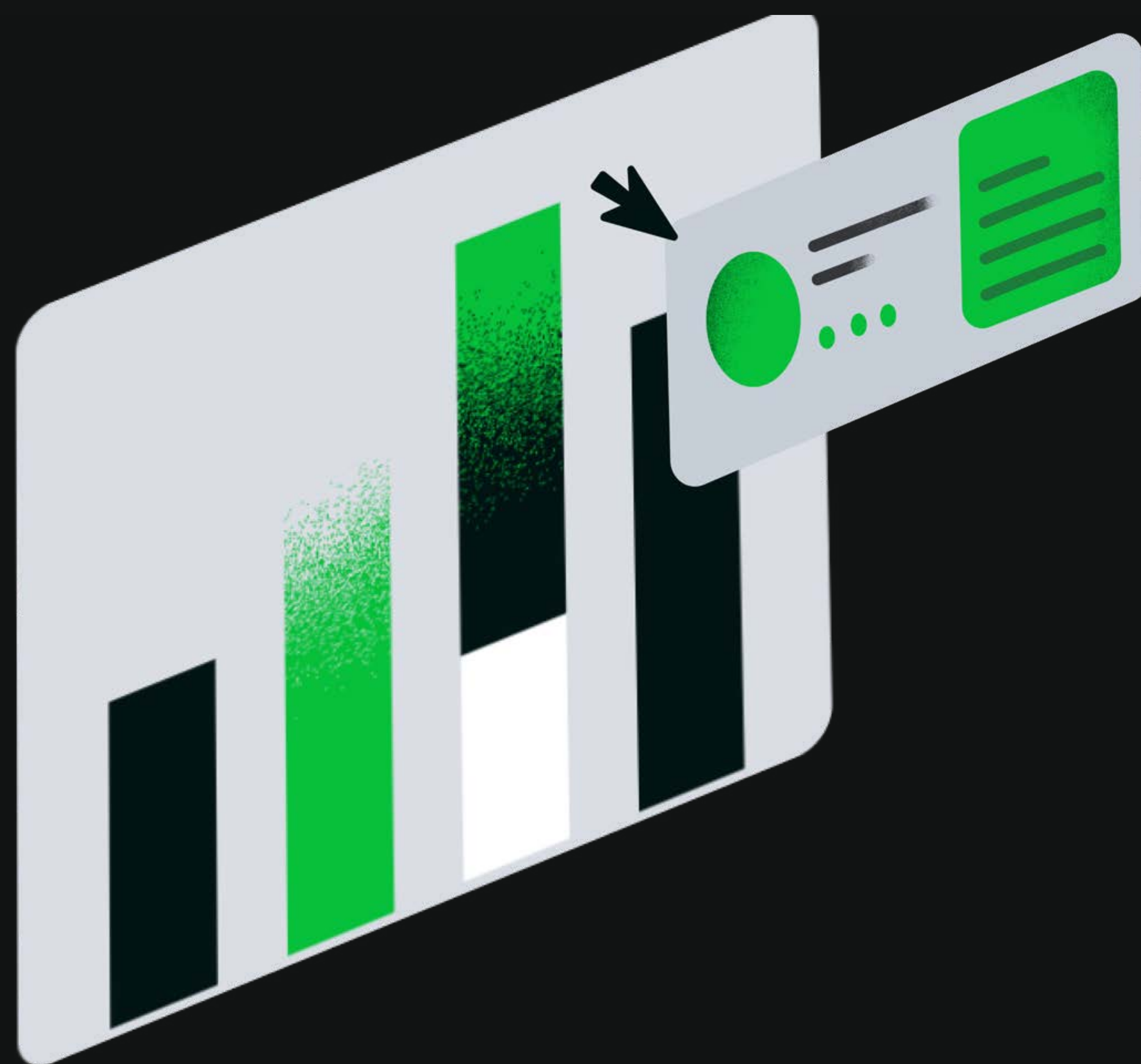
Pictory immediately created an affiliate program following its launch. They used a tool called Rewardful, which allowed them to quickly give Sumo-lings a big reason to promote Pictory to their friends, family, and followers.

Today, 84% of their total revenue comes from untracked referrals and 30% of this comes from tracked affiliate links.

③ Strategic options and add-ons

Pictory also wanted a way to give their top Sumo-lings a way to get even more out of the tool. They did this by offering upgraded plans. Sumo-lings could either double the usage limits of the LTD for \$19 per month or add an extra 10,000 emails for \$9 per month.

As we covered in the upsell section, this was a natural way to give enthusiastic customers more reasons to use Pictory.



05

Repeat campaigns on AppSumo

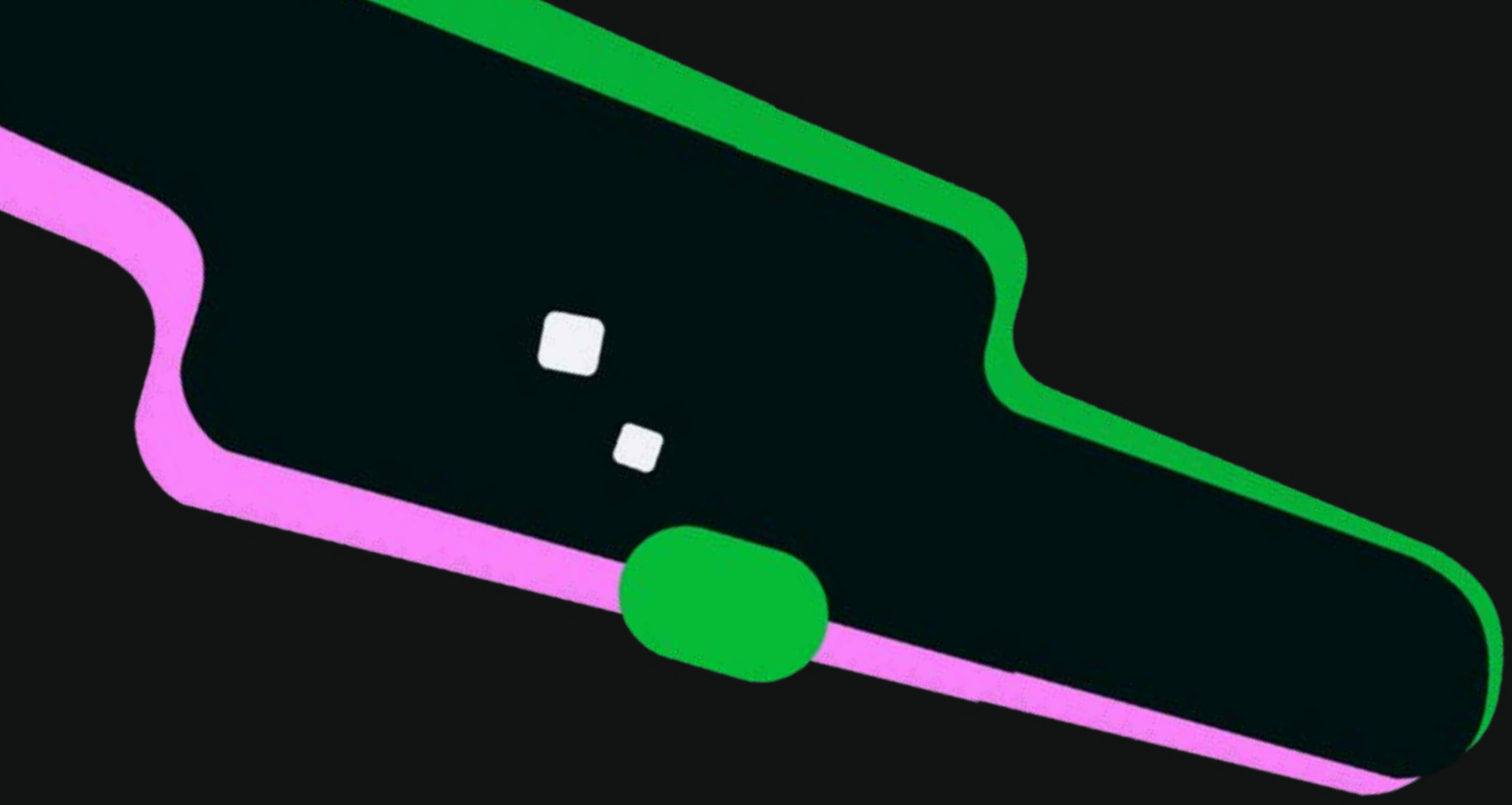


Our favorite partner collaborations are the ones we get to have again and again.

Here's a little internal AppSumo secret: What you do after your first launch matters to us. If you continue to expand the product, impress your customers, and grow a solid community around your tool, we're likely to want you back for round two (and three, and four...).

If you're interested in coming back to AppSumo, here are a few strategies for making a high-impact second launch:

- **Give Sumo-lings an even bigger product:** With all the fresh feedback from your first launch, you can make the next launch even greater than the first. Your next deal can include everything from the first, plus all the new gizmos and gadgets you've added in the meantime.
- **Give Sumo-lings an even sweeter deal:** What's something that could truly fulfill the dreams of Sumo-lings? The chance to buy a better deal at the same price. Sure, a second deal with expanded features is a decent reason to raise the price. But the most powerful deals are the ones where the price stays the same, and the features are better than ever.
- **A second chance for the ones who missed out:** Even if your core product remains about the same, a second launch of a popular deal can give Sumo-lings another chance to purchase your product. Cure some FOMO and welcome the new customers.
- **Turn first-time learnings into an even bigger second launch:** Every partner learns a lot about their own brand, product, and strategy by launching on AppSumo. You can get years of feedback packed into just a few weeks. A second launch is your opportunity to take the big learnings from the first and put them to work—so the next launch is even bigger and better.



AppSumo as a launchpad

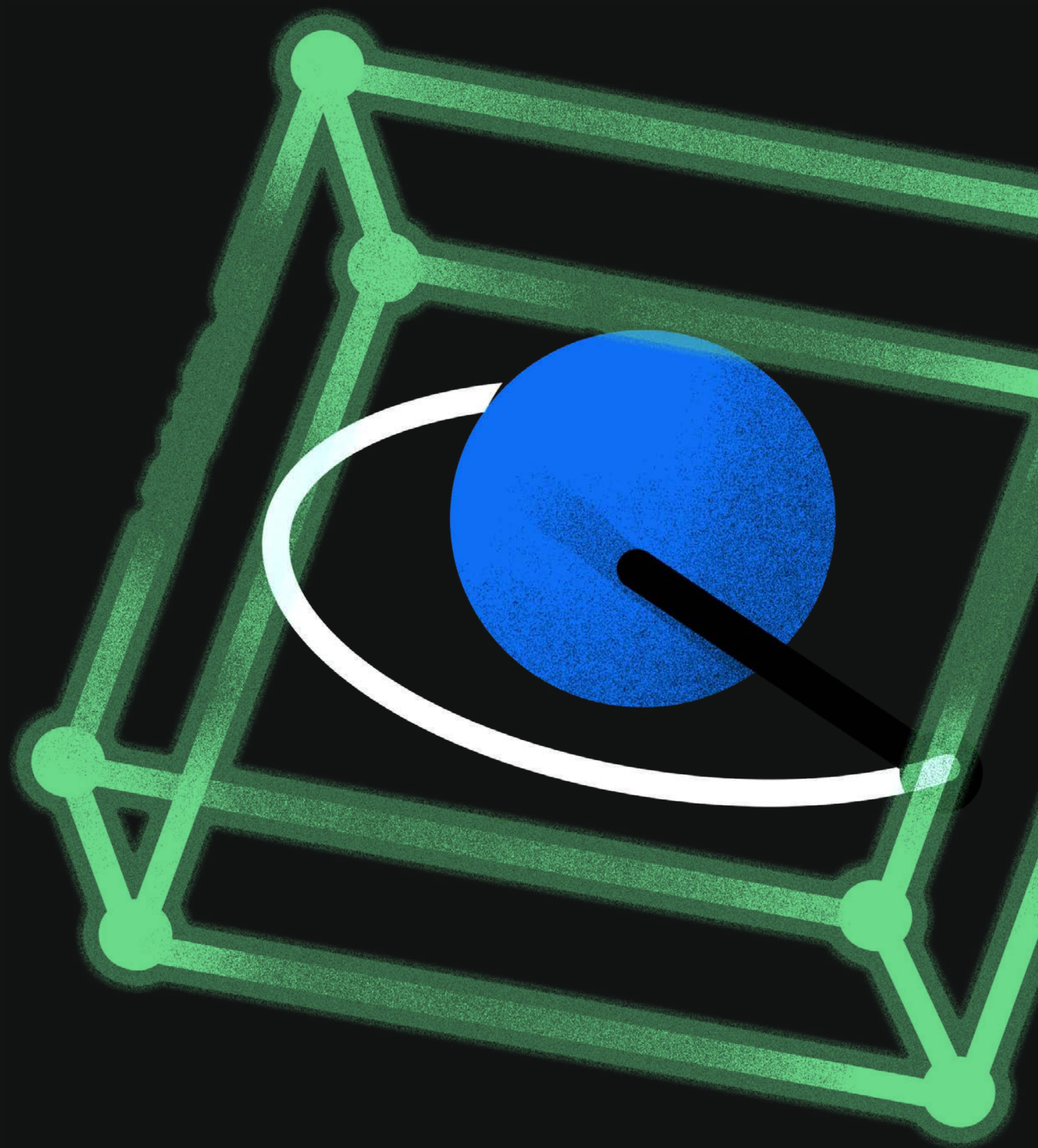
Believe it or not, your AppSumo launch was only the beginning.

What you choose to do next can greatly impact the speed and direction of your company's growth from now on.

Over the years, we've been part of thousands of product launches and have had the pleasure of watching many of our partners achieve incredible success.

To write this article, we identified patterns across the most successful AppSumo launches. Then we condensed our findings into this playbook—to help companies (like yours!) achieve wilder success than you've ever imagined.

Good luck!



Keep AppSumo in the loop

REMINDER: Maintain proper and consistent communication with Sumo-lings and the AppSumo team around product changes

Notify your BD manager at AppSumo for assistance on comms pertaining to:

- Plan changes
- Dormant account notices
- Ownership change
- Material changes to the product
- Other announcements
- Issues with problematic customers

